# Match Squad

Product Intern Case Study

**Part 1 — Reading the First 100 Levels**
**Part 2 — Anatomy of a Single Level**
**Part 3 — Design a Villain and Its Dice Obstacle**

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**Method:** I played levels 1–100 on a fresh account and logged every level as I went: objective, target counts, moves granted, obstacles present, attempts needed and moves remaining on the win. The complete log is attached as a spreadsheet (`match_squad_case_log.xlsx`); every number and every chart in this document is drawn from it. The recording for level 97 was lost, so only its attempt count survives.

## 1. The obstacle vocabulary

Across the first 100 levels the game introduces **18 obstacles**. Fourteen appear on ordinary levels; four belong to bosses and are never seen outside a Clash level. The table below is the whole vocabulary at a glance; the profiles that follow give each obstacle's concept, mechanic, and—the part I found most revealing—whether its art actually teaches its rule.

| # | Obstacle | Lvl | How it is cleared | Hits | Clarity |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | Vase | 1 | match adjacent | 1 | **5** |
| 2 | Crate | 2 | match adjacent, one layer per match | 1–3 | **5** |
| 3 | Jelly | 3 | match *inside* it — it spreads, it is never cleared | n/a | **3** |
| 4 | Sphere • | 5 | match adjacent | 1 | **5** |
| 5 | Sapphire | 7 | match adjacent, one segment per match | per cell | **3** |
| 6 | Ivy | 11 | match adjacent to the exposed edge, one layer per match | 1–2 | **3** |
| 7 | Slime • | 15 | match adjacent | 1 | **5** |
| 8 | Jackpot | 16 | match adjacent to collect gems; never destroyed | n/a | **5** |
| 9 | Cardboard | 21 | open the shutter, then match adjacent — match size scales the damage | many | **3** |
| 10 | Lantern | 31 | match adjacent, one layer per match | 2 | **5** |
| 11 | Border • | 35 | match adjacent to break and reveal | 1 | **5** |
| 12 | Ice | 41 | match tiles *on* it, one layer per match | 2 | **5** |
| 13 | Crystals | 51 | open the cabinet, then match its colour beside it | 1 per crystal | **4** |
| 14 | Dino Egg | 61 | match adjacent twice — it releases an ally | 2 | **5** |
| 15 | Soil | 71 | five matches against the *same* cell | 5 | **2** |
| 16 | Laser • | 75 | boosters only | 4 | **3** |
| 17 | Gnome | 81 | boosters only | 1 | **3** |
| 18 | Gong | 91 | match adjacent | 8 | **3** |

• boss obstacle. *Clarity* is my own 1–5 rating of how well the visual communicates the rule before the tutorial explains it. n/a: Not Applicable

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**Clarity Scale:**

***1*** — *The visual said nothing, even misled*
***2*** — *Even after the tutorial, I couldn't make sense of its logic*
***3*** — *When I read the popup, I said "okay, makes sense"*
***4*** — *I almost understood, the popup confirmed it*
***5*** — *No popup was needed at all, I understood as soon as I looked*

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### 1.1 Obstacle profiles

## 1. Vase

introduced at level 1

**Concept:** It looks like a ceramic vase with orange and white stripes. Its shiny texture emphasizes that it is something fragile.

**Mechanic:** The obstacle can swap places with tiles on the board; it is not fixed in place. It breaks as soon as a match is made next to it. A single-layer obstacle.

**Does the concept teach the mechanic? 5/5.** Breaking it by matching beside it felt intuitive - a jar is a breakable object, and the read was strong.

**Why it matters?** The perfect first obstacle: one hit, one verb, one visual promise.

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## 2. Crate

introduced at level 2

**Concept:** While its single-layer form could be any obstacle if it weren't for the line in the middle, the line makes it clear that it is a wooden crate. Wooden blocks added on top come into play to add layers to the objective. Every nailed wooden block adds one more layer to the obstacle. The non-perfect rectangular shape of the nailed wooden blocks shows us that they are also wood.

**Mechanic:** It can have multiple layers. It varies between 3 layers and 1 layer. When single-layered, it is in the form of a box. As extra layers are added, wooden pieces are added on top of the box. Its place does not change, and it is fixed. Each match destroys one layer.

**Does the concept teach the mechanic? 5/5.** Since it was parallel to obstacles in similar games, I understood what to do even before the tutorial.

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## 3. Jelly

introduced at level 3

**Concept:** At first, it looked like a purple liquid with air bubbles inside, but the motionless bubbles strengthened the feeling that it was not a liquid. Its expanding animation convinced me that the obstacle had a jelly structure, but to strengthen the jelly feel, an animation might be needed at the moment the tiles on the board fall into the jelly as well.

**Mechanic:** The goal is to spread the jelly. To spread it, the tile inside the jelly needs to make a match, or by using the booster inside the jelly. The main key point is that the match to be made or the booster to be used must be inside the jelly. Boosters spread as much as their area of effect. In matches made, it spreads to as many cells as the area occupied by the tiles.

**Does the concept teach the mechanic? 3/5.** When I read the popup, I said "okay, makes sense".

**Why it matters?** It provides a goal to be achieved rather than an obstacle to be overcome.

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## 4. Sphere (boss obstacle)

introduced at level 5

**Concept:** With its moving pink-purple gradient transitions, purple smoke coming out from behind, and shiny texture, it gives the vibe of a magical glass sphere. The gold color and diamond grains used also create the image of an expensive object that the Baron might own. The glass texture creates fragility in the obstacle.

**Mechanic:** The obstacle can swap places with tiles on the board; it is not fixed in place. It breaks as soon as a match is made next to it. Every 4 moves, the Baron places 4 more spheres on the board.

**Does the concept teach the mechanic? 5/5.** I thought damage would be dealt by making matches, and that's how it turned out.

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## 5. Sapphire

introduced at level 7

**Concept:** They look like tall blue diamonds or ice blocks. I didn't understand what the mechanism underneath was until the game started. I thought it was a technological device inside an orange frame. After playing the game, when looking closely and in slow motion, I saw gears shredding the object above. But along with the in-game sound effect, you realize it's a grinder.

**Mechanic:** With every match made next to it, a bar goes down. However many cells long the sapphire is, that many matches are required.

**Does the concept teach the mechanic? 3/5.** I thought the direction of the match made might be important when grinding the sapphire. I assumed that a vertically extending sapphire would take damage

from a vertical match. I thought a rocket aligned in the same direction as the sapphire could grind the sapphire completely.

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## 6. Ivy

introduced at level 11

**Concept:** It consists of dense leaves in purple, dark blue, and blue tones. When it has a two-layer structure, there are white and orange flowers on top.

**Mechanic:** When single-layered, there are only purple leaves. When double-layered, it has a flowery, leafy appearance. Its place does not change, and it is fixed. Each match destroys one layer.

**Does the concept teach the mechanic? 3/5.** Based on its name and dense leaf texture, I thought it was an expanding obstacle. In terms of obstacle dynamics, since it was very similar to the crate, I thought it would have a different dynamic.

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## 7. Slime (boss obstacle)

introduced at level 15

**Concept:** It has a green, jelly-like, and fluid structure. The green liquid dripping from the bottom when it swallows an object reinforces its fluidity.

**Mechanic:** The boss's energy recharges in 6 moves, and when it's full, 3 more slime cells are added. Matching with other slime is necessary to destroy it. If the slime takes no damage after a move, it spreads another cell.

**Does the concept teach the mechanic? 5/5.** It became clearer because it came after jelly.

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## 8. Jackpot

introduced at level 16

**Concept:** It looks like a slot machine with a pink diamond shape in its center. As you make matches next to it, the slot machine arm moves, the diamond shape spins on its screen, and a diamond flies up into the air.

**Mechanic:** Each adjacent match yields exactly 1 gem, regardless of match size. Once all its gems are collected its shutter closes. The jackpot is fixed. Its position does not change.

**Does the concept teach the mechanic?5/5.** The name and the slot-machine framing do all the work.

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## 9. Cardboard

introduced at level 21

**Concept:** Before taking the first damage, it looks like a shop with its shutter closed. After taking damage, the shutter opens, and cards are laid out with an animation similar to a peacock unfolding its feathers. There are 5 cards in each row, making two rows in total. If it hadn't said "collect cards" at the start of the game, I might have had difficulty recognizing them as cards. Having thin white borders on the sides and a slightly thicker one on the upper edge gave the impression of a technological screen rather than a card.

**Mechanic:** To open the shutter, a match, boost, or anything can be used. After the shutter opens, as many cards leave the Cardboard as the number of tiles matched next to it. A rocket takes 2 cards, and with TNT, as many cards leave as the number of cells Cardboard falls into TNT's area of effect. Cardboard occupies a 4x4 cell space.

**Does the concept teach the mechanic? 3/5.** I played and saw how many cards the matches made would take away.

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## 10. Lantern

introduced at level 31

**Concept:** Before its light turned on, it might have been difficult to understand what it was. But that ray of light while the light is burning shows us that this is an oil lamp. The gold-colored holding apparatus on top also reinforces this feeling. My only suggestion here would be for the light to turn on first and go out after taking damage. It would have felt more correct to me in terms of logic and understanding the visual.

**Mechanic:** It has two layers. At the first layer of damage, the lamp lights up. Afterward, it breaks and disappears. Each match destroys one layer. It can swap places with other tiles.

**Does the concept teach the mechanic? 5/5.** No popup was needed at all, I understood as soon as I looked.

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## 11. Border (boss obstacle)

introduced at level 35

**Concept:** Since the diagonal yellow and purple stripes are an in-game copy of the impassable tape we see in our daily lives, the message it gives is very strong. Metal connection points, nails, and the Boss wearing

construction clothes also reinforced this message.
**Mechanic:** Carver boss adds 4 more to the existing target count every 7 moves. But to be honest, I couldn't solve the border obstacle algorithm. I couldn't establish a numerical connection or algorithm between the goal count and the obstacle visible on the board. It breaks when matched next to it. It is a fixed target itself.
**Does the concept teach the mechanic? 5/5.** However, I still haven't fully understood the algorithm of what the target count is based on; I just understood what I needed to do as soon as I saw the obstacle.
**Why it matters?** The only obstacle that attacks information rather than space. Its real flaw is legibility: the goal counter and the visible board never reconcile, so the player cannot plan a rare case where difficulty comes from confusion rather than from the puzzle.

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## 12. Ice

introduced at level 41

**Concept:** The snow texture has been created very successfully; it is understood to be snow without a second glance. The snow turns into ice after taking damage. As the obstacle takes damage, snowflakes scatter around. The ice appearance is provided with a texture similar to an ice rink so as not to be confused with a glass appearance. The roughness and cracks make it feel like a shiny and transparent surface, not glass.
**Mechanic:** You deal damage by matching tiles on top of the ice. A two-layered obstacle. The first layer is snow, the second layer is ice. It doesn't move; its location is fixed. Game tiles sit on top of Ice.
**Does the concept teach the mechanic? 5/5.** No popup was needed at all, I understood as soon as I looked.

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## 13. Crystals

introduced at level 51

**Concept:** Before taking damage, it has a design that is a mix of a bank vault and a kitchen cabinet. A sturdy and thick design, but a hinged cabinet door. Its blue shiny surface makes it look like a metal cabinet. The valuable item inside also reinforces the vault-or-cabinet duality. The cabinet door breaks open, revealing colorful, shiny, diamond-like stones inside. The cabinet has two shelves, with a total of 4 crystals at the top and bottom.
**Mechanic:** To open the cabinet, a match must first be made next to the cabinet. After that, whatever colors the crystals inside the cabinet are, matches of those colors must be made next to the cabinet to break the crystal of that color. Using a booster takes away one crystal. In some levels, there can also be single-colored crystals in the cabinet.
**Does the concept teach the mechanic? 4/5.** Since it came after the Cardboard obstacle, I understood how the course of action would be, but I still needed to try it out in the game; since a color condition was set, I wasn't sure if boosters would be effective on the crystal. I thought it could only take damage under the condition of a color match.
**Why it matters?** The only colour-locked obstacle. Matching according to color increases the tactical difficulty of the game.

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## 14. Dino Egg

introduced at level 61

**Concept:** A design parallel to the familiar dinosaur egg illustration. When the egg takes damage, it cracks and a cute reptile emerges from inside. The reptiles blink, look around, and are startled by explosions. We are convinced that the obstacle is a living creature. Upon taking damage once more, the dinos take off with their wings and hit a random target with the fire they spew from their mouths.
**Mechanic:** A two-layered obstacle. The first layer is an egg, and in the second layer, there is a dino about to hatch from the egg. A match must be made next to it or it must take damage from a booster. In both cases, only a single layer takes damage. When dinos are freed, they hit random tiles on the board by spewing flames from their mouths. These can sometimes be targeted obstacles too. In this respect, it is a more cooperative obstacle.
**Does the concept teach the mechanic? 5/5.** I was surprised that the dinos were cooperative.
**Why it matters?** It is a cooperative obstacle.

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## 15. Soil

introduced at level 71

**Concept:** At first glance, it looks more like an orangey-brownish plate than soil. The initial guesses of people around me were clay. As matches are made, mines appear, and explosions occur, people become convinced

that they are mines and understand that the initial obstacle was soil. However, it is difficult to understand that it is soil at first glance.
**Mechanic:** The size of the soil blocks can vary from level to level. Other obstacles can also be hidden under the soil. After being destroyed, other obstacles are revealed as well. To completely destroy a single soil block, a cell within the block needs to take damage 5 times. Afterward, an entire block breaks apart. As cells take damage, the soil erodes and a mine appears, and on the 5th damage, the mine explodes. A fixed obstacle that does not change places.
**Does the concept teach the mechanic? 2/5.** I couldn't figure out how to destroy the obstacle at first.

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## 16. Laser (boss obstacle)

introduced at level 75

**Concept:** An antenna-like technological device in purple tones. The boss of the obstacle is also in a more futuristic costume, which shows the player that they might be facing an obstacle straight out of sci-fi.
**Mechanic:** To destroy the Lasers, they need to be hit 4 times with a booster. However, every 7 moves, the laser boy increases the health of the lasers by 1 bar. When a booster is formed, the lasers lock onto it in their radar, and if the laser taking aim doesn't take damage on the next move, it locks the targeted booster. To unlock it, a match must be made next to the booster.
**Does the concept teach the mechanic? 3/5.** When I read the popup, I said "okay, makes sense".
**Why it matters.** It is the only one that runs a two-way loop with the player's own resources: boosters are the only weapon, and the laser confiscates them.

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## 17. Gnome

introduced at level 81

**Concept:**With its red helmet and shoes, it could even be compared to a daisy. Since I am familiar with such styles, I understood what it was, but the people whose opinions I asked had difficulty comparing it to a Gnome. Perhaps small changes made to the hat and beard would make a visual difference.
**Mechanic.** One booster hit destroys it.
**Does the concept teach the mechanic? 3/5.** Since it was already an obstacle in the form of an object that could be destroyed with enough matches, I thought a different method might be necessary. It was no surprise that it was destroyed with a booster.

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## 18. Gong

introduced at level 91

**Concept:** It has the appearance of a coded antique safe. As matches are made, it looks as if keys are being pressed. And when all keys are pressed, with a click effect, it transforms into a large spinning, color-changing crystal surrounded by a cloud of mysterious letters, altering the color of the tiles on the board.
**Mechanic:** It needs to take damage 8 times, either by making matches or with a booster. Whichever color the large spinning crystal on the board turns into last, it transforms a color on the board into that color. When this happens, surprise boosters can form on the board, or obstacles can take damage thanks to the resulting matches.
**Does the concept teach the mechanic? 3/5.** When I read the popup, I said "okay, makes sense".
**Why it matters?** The second cooperative one after Dino Egg.

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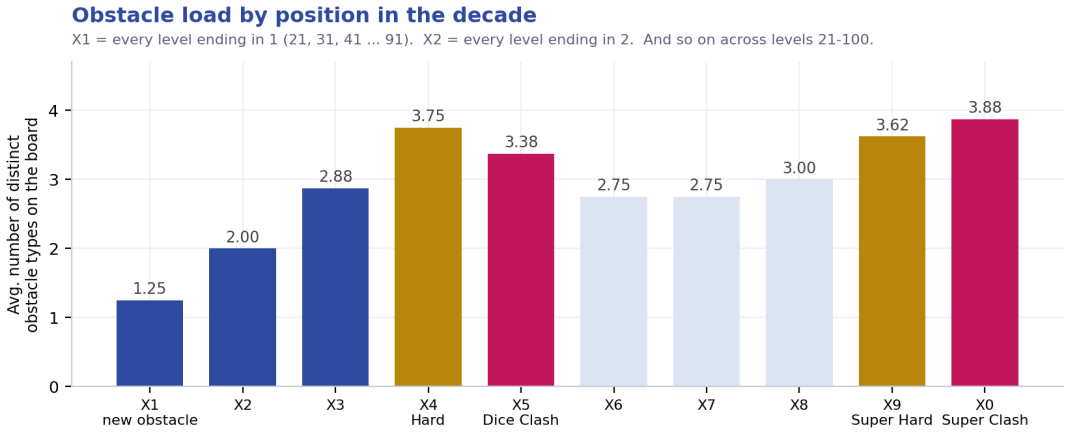
## 2. How the first 100 levels are built?

### 2.1 The decade is the unit of design

From level 21 onwards the game runs a ten-level template, and it runs it without a single exception across all eight remaining decades:

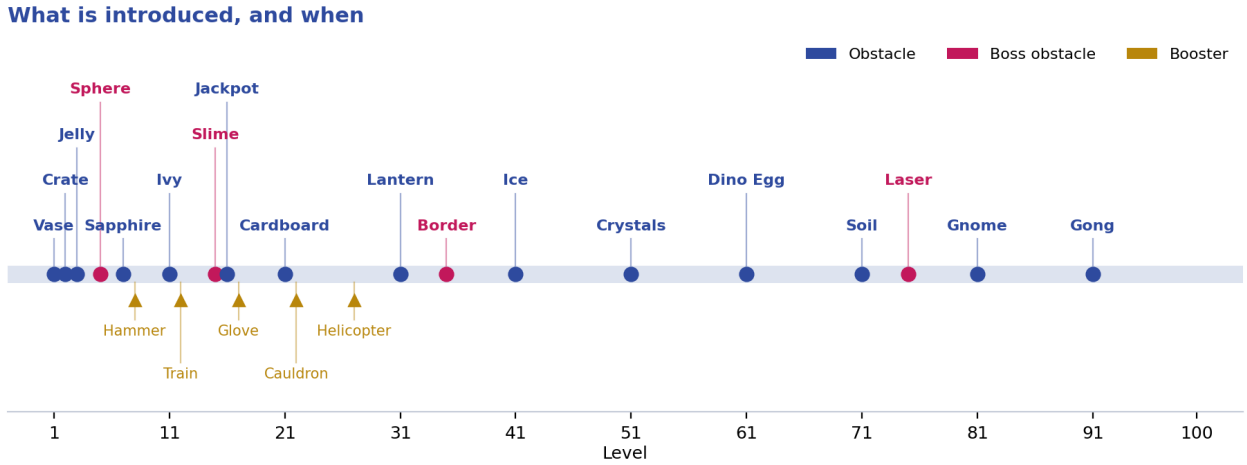
| Position | Level type | Bonus | Function |
|---|---|---|---|
| **X1** | Normal | — | **New obstacle, alone on the board** |
| **X2** | Normal | — | New obstacle *plus exactly one* known obstacle |
| X3 | Normal | — | A third obstacle enters |
| **X4** | **Hard** | ×2 | The new mechanic at full complexity |
| **X5** | **Dice Clash** | ×5 | Boss |
| X6–X8 | Normal | — | The older pool rotates; the new obstacle returns at X6 and X8 |
| **X9** | **Super Hard** | ×3 | Second ramp |
| **X0** | **Super Clash** | ×10 | Boss |

This is why the brief excludes levels ending in 1 or 2 from Part 2: **X1 teaches and X2 rehearses**, so both are tutorial levels. The exclusion is a description of the architecture. The obstacle count follows the template exactly, one new obstacle per level for the first four levels of every decade:




The shape is a double sawtooth: build for four levels, peak at Hard, exhale through X6–X8, then climb again to the Super Clash. Levels 1–20 are the exception.

### 2.2 Introduction schedules

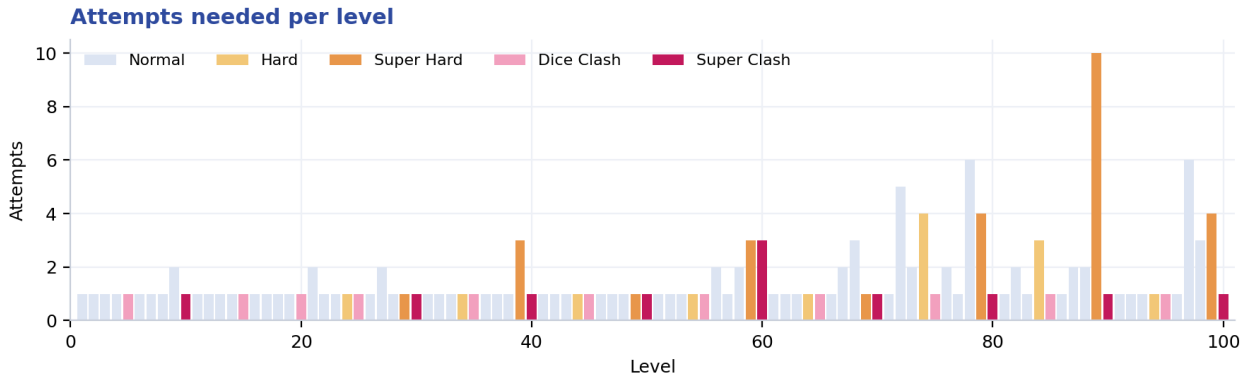


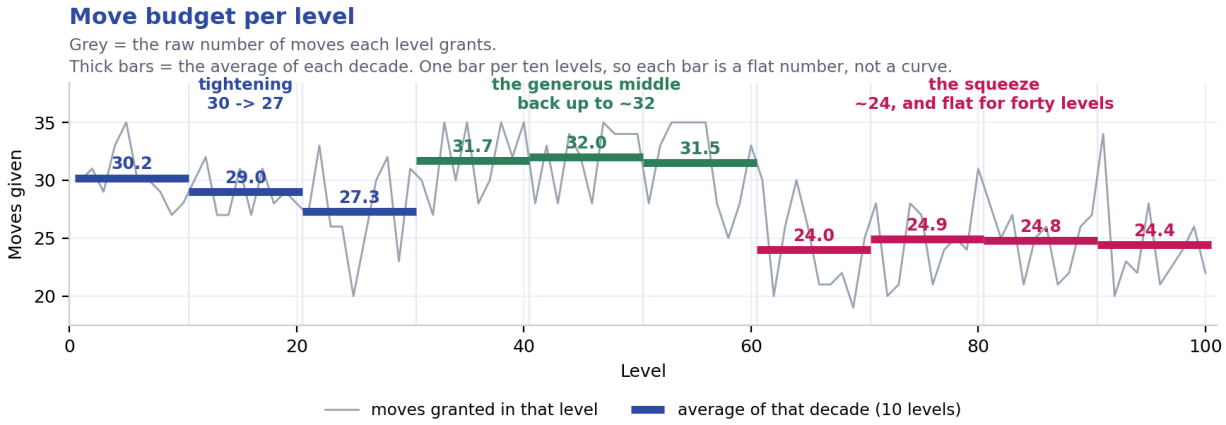

**Ordinary obstacles** arrive on the opening level of each decade: 21, 31, 41, 51, 61, 71, 81, 91. Perfectly regular. **Boss obstacles** arrive only on Clash levels — 5, 15, 35, 75 — with gaps of 10, 20 and 40. The remaining sixteen Clash levels rotate those same four obstacles, which is how the game gets twenty distinct boss fights out of four assets. **Boosters** arrive between levels 8 and 27: Hammer (8), Train (12), Glove (17),

Cauldron (22), Helicopter (27). Every one is taught with the same pattern as an obstacle forced highlight, popup, three pre-loaded chargesand every one costs no move. The player's whole toolkit is complete by level 27.

**The clearest single decision in the pacing:** a new obstacle appears on X1, X2, X3 and X4 without a break, and then returns at X6 and X8 with a two-level gap. The game teaches, then tests, then lets you forget just enough to have to remember.

## 2.3 Difficulty




| | Levels 1–50 | Levels 51–100 |
|---|---|---|
| Average attempts per level | 1.10 | **2.00** |
| Average moves granted | 30.0 | **26.0** |
| First-try clear rate (all 100 levels) | 76 % | |

Attempts roughly double while the move budget falls by four. The two curves move against each other, which is the actual mechanism of the difficulty ramp. Not harder obstacles, but the same obstacles with less moves. My own experience matches the data: the first-try rate collapsed after level 55, and levels 72–74 were the first run of consecutive levels that each cost me several attempts. Level 89 took ten.

## 2.4 Why I think it is built this

**The decade solves the teaching problem and the content problem at the same time.** A fixed template means a level designer never has to decide what *kind* of level to build next — only which obstacles to put in it.

**Variety comes from combination, not from invention.** Eighteen obstacles generate a hundred essentially unique levels.

**Bosses escalate by mixing, not by inventing.** Level 5's boss level contains only Spheres. Level 10's contains Spheres plus Crate plus Sapphire. By level 95 a Clash level carries five different obstacles. The boss is used as an exam on everything learned so far. The difficulty lives in the boss's counter, not in the object.

### 2.5 Where it works least well

**Soil (level 71) is the most confusing obstacle for me.** I only understood it by trial. It is also the one obstacle several people could not identify at all: it reads as an orange-brown slab, and the most common guess was clay.

**Border (35) attacks information rather than space,** which is a genuinely interesting idea, but the goal counter and the visible board never reconcile. After twenty levels containing it I still could not predict how the target number related to what I could see. Difficulty that comes from opacity is different from difficulty that comes from the puzzle.

**Lantern (31) could have placed earlier.** It moves with the tiles, carries two layers. It is an easy, legible obstacle that would have taught the "two hits" idea far earlier than level 31.

## 3. Anatomy of a single level: Level 54

I chose Level 54 because of where it sits and the game's C-shaped flow intrigued me. It occupies the X4 slot — the *Hard* position in the decade template — which is the slot whose job is to test the decade's new obstacle at full complexity.




### 3.1 Obstacle selection

The level uses Ivy, Sapphire, Crystals and Ice. What makes them work together is that **none of them competes for the same space** — they are stacked in four strata:

- **Ivy** sits on top, at the surface, and must be eaten from its exposed edge.
- **Sapphire** spans the middle as five vertical columns, ground from the grinders at their feet.
- **Crystals** are sealed containers to the right — opened first, then colour-matched.
- **Ice** is the floor underneath the sapphires and the cabinets.

Because they are layered rather than adjacent, clearing each one is what grants access to the next. Four obstacles placed side by side would be four parallel chores; here they form a single chain, and that chain is the level. It is also worth naming what the level does *not* use. None of the four obstacles is active: no counter, no spawning, nothing that acts on its own. Level 54 buys its difficulty entirely with space

### 3.2 Board placement

Three placement decisions define this level.

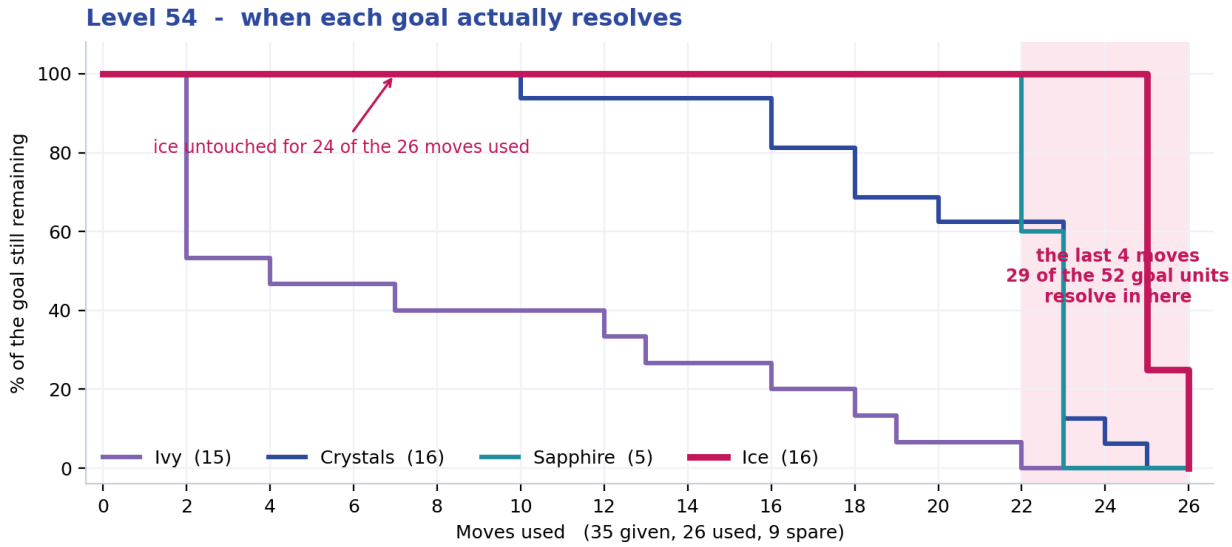
**The free area is tiny and badly positioned — deliberately.** At move one exactly 16 of the board's 82 cells are playable, and they sit in the top-right corner, the point furthest from every single goal. The level opens by telling you that you do not yet have room to pursue anything.

**The dead zone is the enforcer.** The empty rectangle in the middle-right is not decoration. It bends the board into a C, but more importantly it *severs access to the crystal cabinets from above*. Without it there would be two viable routes down the board and the solution order would be a matter of taste. One empty rectangle removes the alternative and makes the order singular.

**The sapphires are a self-balancing ramp.** Their heights descend away from the free area: the tallest column, which needs the most matches, is the furthest from where you start. So the cost per column rises as you advance — but by the time you reach it you have more open board and more special pieces.

### 3.3 Flow

There is exactly one legal opening. From the top-right pocket the only direction that opens space is left, along the top, into the ivy. From there the board unrolls: down the left flank through the sapphires, then right along the bottom into the cabinets, and finally the ice underneath. The route traces the C.




The chart is the most interesting thing about this level. **The ice counter reads 16 and does not move for 24 of the 26 moves I used.** Sapphire is frozen at 5 for 21 of them, and the crystal counter gives up only 6 of its 16 gems in the first twenty moves. Then the level ends in an avalanche: **29 of the 52 goal units — 56% of everything the level asks for — resolve in the final four moves**, and the whole of Ice, which is 31% of the total on its own, falls in the last two. Four-fifths of the level is excavation with almost nothing to show for it, and the payoff arrives all at once.

### 3.4 What I think is strong

**The board writes its own solution order:** The sequence in which I completed the goals — ivy, sapphire, crystals, ice — is the same sequence in which the board can be read, top to bottom around the C.

**The four obstacles form a chain rather than a list:** Each clearance is the key to the next. It is what gives the level a sense of progression even while three of the four counters are stationary.

**The hardest constraint arrives at the easiest moment:** Crystals demand a specific colour matched beside a specific cabinet — the most restrictive requirement in the level. It lands last, when the board is at its most open and special pieces are plentiful. The level is arranged so that its tightest demand meets the player at their strongest.

### 3.5 What I think is weak

**Variance decided the ending:** In the final quarter a Powerball formed out of a cascade I had not planned. It is the cliff on the chart: in one move the crystal counter falls from 10 to 2 and sapphire empties completely. It made the remainder trivial. I cleared it first try with 9 moves spare and without spending a single booster — and I am not confident that outcome was repeatable.

**And the Hard label does not mean much.** This is not specific to Level 54. Across all 100 levels:

| Level type | n | Avg attempts | First try | Avg moves granted |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Normal | 64 | 1.45 | 75 % | 27.7 |
| **Hard** (×2) | 8 | **1.62** | **75 %** | 28.2 |
| Super Hard (×3) | 8 | **3.38** | **38 %** | 26.5 |
| **Dice Clash** (×5) | 11 | **1.00** | **100 %** | 29.3 |
| Super Clash (×10) | 9 | 1.22 | 89 % | 29.6 |

**Hard is statistically indistinguishable from Normal** — 1.62 attempts against 1.45, with an identical 75 % first-try rate — while carrying a ×2 reward.

### 3.6 What I think the designer was solving

My reading is that the brief for this level was something like: *test Crystals without making a colour-matching drill.* A board where four cabinets sit in the open would reduce to "make green matches next to the blue box" sixteen times — mechanically correct and completely inert. The solution was to bury them. The colour constraint is unchanged, but reaching it becomes a spatial problem, and by the time the player gets there the board has opened enough that the constraint is satisfiable. The excavation is not padding in front of the real level; it is what converts a repetitive requirement into a paced one. That is also why the ice is underneath everything. It is not a fourth objective so much as a **receipt** — it can only be completed if the other three were done in the right order.

## 4. A new villain: TEMPEST

### 4.1 The gap I am designing into

All four bosses in the first 100 levels run a move counter: Baron adds 4 Spheres every 4 moves, the Slime boss adds 3 Slimes every 6, Carver adds 4 to the goal counter every 7. Only the Laser boy does something else — it heals itself and confiscates the player's boosters. So the roster attacks exactly two things: the number of goals, and the player's resources.

Nothing attacks the board.

That is the sharper version of an observation already in Part 1a. Every one of the 18 obstacles I catalogued acts inside its own cell — it spawns, it blocks, it sits under a tile, it occupies space. Not one of them touches tiles the player is not already looking at. The obstacle that comes closest to something else is Border at level 35, which attacks the player's information about the board's *present* state. TEMPEST is that idea moved one step forward: it attacks the player's information about their *next move*.

### 4.2 The villain

TEMPEST is an old pig in a white and gold robe with a violet mantle, leaning on a staff topped with a violet orb. The face does the work: heavy white brows pulled down over small angry eyes, a long beard, a body that is round and slow rather than sharp. Tutorial popup: *"Make a match next to BOLT to defeat TEMPEST!"* *"TEMPEST will stir the board every 5 moves!"*



**The orb is not decoration — it is the mechanic's tell.** It is the thing that lights up one move before the storm arrives, so the warning lives on the character.

### 4.3 The obstacle: BOLT

A BOLT is a lightning bolt held inside a violet storm cloud, occupying one cell. Match beside it and it breaks: one hit, no layers, no colour requirement. That is deliberately the most familiar clearing verb in the game.



The cloud says where the object came from — it belongs to the storm, not to the board — so the obstacle and the villain are legible as one system before any text is read. And the palette is deliberate: A BOLT can never be misread as a matchable tile.

**Note on the artwork:** The character and obstacle images above are concept art I generated with ChatGPT's image tool from my own written brief.

At level 5 the Sphere is mechanically identical to the Vase introduced at level 1 — same verb, same single hit — and the whole of Baron's difficulty lives in his counter rather than in the object. TEMPEST repeats that structure on purpose. If the obstacle is something the player already knows, the only thing left to learn is the storm.

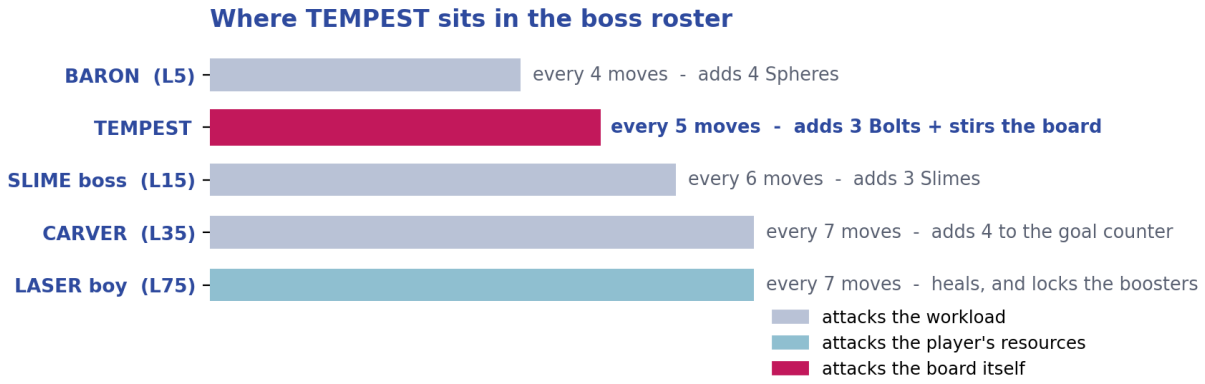
### 4.4 Rules

Stir, if poorly designed, reads as "bad luck" rather than "adapt." The difference is defined by these five rules:

1. **Tile Restriction:** Only loose coloured tiles shuffle. obstacles, boosters stay in place. Otherwise, a layered board like L54 becomes unreadable, and the tornado ends up moving the targets themselves.
2. **Fair Board State:** Stir can never produce free matches. Unsaid, the boss would sometimes hand out gifts.
3. **One Move Advance Warning:** The staff starts glowing on the 4th move. Without this rule, your intention is unreachable — you cannot adapt to what you cannot see, you merely suffer it. The warning is what turns the event from "randomness" into a "deadline."
4. **BOLT Drop Rules:** 3 BOLTs drop after the shuffle, at least one square away from each other, in visible spots — no clustering.
5. **Cap Mechanism:** There should be a "cap", but I'm not sure what the number should be yet. If the "cap" limit has been reached the tornado still comes, but leaves nothing behind.

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### 4.5 Where TEMPEST sits



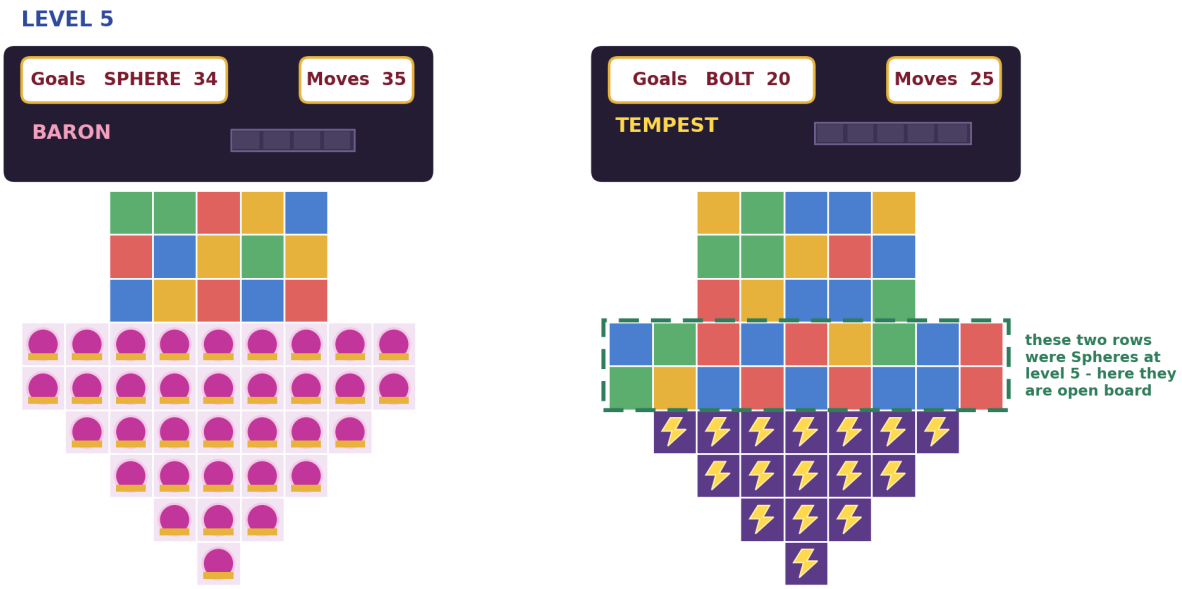

The 5-move counter is deliberately slower than Baron's 4. The stir carries pressure of its own, and a 4-move stir would leave no window in which a plan can meaningfully exist — the player would stop planning altogether, which is the opposite of the intended behaviour. Five moves is long enough to build something and short enough that you feel the clock while you do it.

### 4.6 The tutorial level

**Why Level 5 is the model?** BOLT is cleared exactly the way SPHERE is cleared: one adjacent match, one hit, no colour requirement. When the clearing dynamic is the same, the teaching should be the same, so Tutorial Level inherits Level 5's frame wholesale. The object needs no re-teaching. Only the storm does.

**But one thing has to be inverted: the field.** Level 5 is a *tight* board. A wedge of 34 Spheres fills it and only 15 of its 49 cells are free. That costs Baron nothing — he adds four Spheres every four moves, so a crowded board is his level. It would cost TEMPEST everything: stirring fifteen tiles inside a pocket produces no meaningful change and therefore no meaningful decision. On a tight board the mechanic does not exist.

So Tutorial Level keeps Level 5's outline and shrinks only the block sitting in it — **16 BOLTS instead of 34 Spheres**, leaving 33 of the 49 cells free instead of 15. Open space is not a comfort here. It is the material the boss works on.




**BOLTS stay in one mass:** Scattering them through a board that is about to be shuffled would make every stir a re-reading exercise rather than a decision — the player would spend the move after each storm working out where everything went, which is fatigue, not difficulty. One block reads at a glance, so the only thing that changes during a stir is the field of loose tiles.

| **Tutorial Level** | |
|---|---|
| Objective | *Destroy BOLT to defeat TEMPEST* |
| Target / moves | 20 BOLTS / 25 moves |
| Board | Level 5's outline, unchanged |
| Other obstacles | none — BOLT is the only variable in the level |
| TEMPEST's counter | every 5 moves: stir the board, add 3 BOLTS. |

**What the player learns, in order?**

1. **Moves 1–4: what a BOLT is:** The board dims except for one legal swap, a hand points at it, the popup names the obstacle in capitals — the game's existing tutorial grammar. A returning player already knows this verb from the Vase at level 1, which is exactly why it is the obstacle.
2. **The counter started:** The storm wakes and only now does the counter start. A stir is a far larger event than a spawn and must not arrive while the player is still working out what a BOLT is.
3. **Every cycle after:** The orb lights up one move ahead. From here the player is planning around the storm rather than reacting to it, which is the whole design.

The level cannot go wrong: no second obstacle to muddy the read, 28 BOLTS available against a goal of 20.

### 4.7 What I am not sure about

**The cap is the one number I would not set from the outside:** If the BOLTS on the board reach a ceiling the storm should still arrive and drop nothing — the tornado comes, the storm has nothing left to throw, which is a good character beat as well as a safety rail. But the right ceiling is a tuning question.

**A stir does not belong on a layered board:** Level 54 works because the board is a one-way door: it only opens, nothing regrows, no state is lost. A TEMPEST level should probably never carry Ice, Crystals or Sapphire, because the value of those obstacles is that the player can reason about what is underneath. Stirring the layer above them would turn a legible excavation into noise. TEMPEST belongs on open boards, which is also where a Clash level usually lives.

**Constantly stiring the board can be tiring:** The stir is the largest visual event in the game. The failure mode is not difficulty but fatigue — a player who stops reading the board because it keeps being rewritten.